Indian Musical Instruments

Knowledge document 089 of 100

Introduction

India has one of the richest and oldest musical instrument traditions in the world, with hundreds of instruments used in classical, folk, devotional and film music. Evidence of musical instruments goes back thousands of years: flutes and drums appear in Indus Valley findings and sculptures, and the ancient Tamil Sangam literature mentions instruments such as the yazh (an ancient harp), the flute (kuzhal), and drums such as the parai. The Natya Shastra of Bharata Muni, written about 2,000 years ago, describes instruments in detail. Instruments are linked with deities: the veena with Saraswati, the flute with Krishna, the damaru with Shiva.

How Are Instruments Classified in Indian Tradition?

In the Indian tradition, musical instruments are classified into four categories, based on the way they produce sound, in a system described in the Natya Shastra and called the Hata or Vadya classification. Tata Vadya, or chordophones, are stringed instruments that produce sound by vibrating strings, such as the veena, sitar, sarod, tambura, violin and santoor. Sushira Vadya, or aerophones, are wind instruments, in which sound is produced by vibrating air, such as the flute (bansuri, venu), shehnai, nadaswaram and conch shell (shankh). Avanaddha Vadya, or membranophones, are percussion instruments with stretched skins, such as the mridangam, tabla, dholak, thavil, dhol, damaru and parai. Ghana Vadya, or idiophones, are solid instruments that make sound when struck or shaken, such as the ghatam (clay pot), manjira, jaltarang (a set of water-filled bowls), cymbals and bells. This is similar to the Western classification by Hornbostel and Sachs into chordophones, aerophones, membranophones and idiophones.

What Is the Veena?

The veena is an ancient plucked string instrument of India, one of the oldest and most revered. The Saraswati veena, used in Carnatic music, is associated with Goddess Saraswati, the goddess of knowledge and music, who is always shown holding it. It has a long, hollow wooden neck with 24 metal frets set in wax, and a large resonating gourd at one end, called the kudam, and a smaller one on the neck, the yazhi, a carved dragon head at the end. It has seven strings: four main strings, played with the fingers of the right hand, for the melody, and three side strings for the rhythm and drone. The musician sits cross-legged and plays with plectra (metal finger picks) on the right hand, while the left hand presses the strings on the frets and produces gamakas, graceful slides and oscillations that sound like the human voice. The veena is often made from jackfruit wood, and Thanjavur is famous for its veena making, with a Geographical Indication tag for the Thanjavur veena. There are many forms: the Rudra veena of Hindustani music, the Vichitra veena, and the Mohan veena, a modern guitar-like version. Famous veena players include Veena Dhanammal, Karaikudi Sambasiva Iyer, S. Balachander, Emani Sankara Sastry, Chitti Babu and Jayanthi Kumaresh.

What Is the Mridangam?

The mridangam is the principal percussion instrument of Carnatic music and is called the "king of percussion instruments" of South India. It is a double-headed barrel-shaped drum, about 60 centimetres long, with a body made of a hollowed-out piece of jackfruit wood, and two skin heads, usually made of goat or cow hide, tied with leather straps. The right face, called the valanthalai, is smaller, with a permanent black circle of a paste made of rice, iron filings and other materials, called soru or karanai, which creates a rich metallic sound. The left face, the thoppi, is larger and produces a deep bass sound, with a paste of wet semolina, or wheat flour, applied just before playing and removed afterwards. The player sits cross-legged with the drum on the lap and strikes it with the fingers and palms of both hands, playing intricate rhythmic patterns and syllables (solkattu) to accompany the vocalist and instrumentalist and in solo performances called thani avartanam. The mridangam is mentioned in ancient Tamil and Sanskrit texts, and it is similar to the pakhawaj of North India. Famous mridangam players include Palghat Mani Iyer, Palani Subramania Pillai, Umayalpuram Sivaraman, Guruvayur Dorai, Karaikudi Mani and T. K. Murthy.

Hindustani and Other Instruments

Famous instruments include the sitar, with Ravi Shankar who made it famous in the world, the sarod played by Ali Akbar Khan and Amjad Ali Khan, the tabla, a pair of hand drums, played by Zakir Hussain and Alla Rakha, the santoor, popularised by Shivkumar Sharma, the bansuri, the bamboo flute, played by Hariprasad Chaurasia, the shehnai, associated with Bismillah Khan, and the sarangi, along with the harmonium, a European reed organ that is now a staple of Indian music, and the tambura, which gives the drone note.

Instruments of Tamil Nadu

The nadaswaram is a long double-reed wind instrument, one of the loudest non-brass acoustic instruments, played with the thavil, a barrel drum, in temples and weddings of Tamil Nadu, and considered auspicious. The violin has been adopted into Carnatic music, with a unique style. The ghatam, an earthen pot played by hitting with fingers, and the kanjira, a small frame drum, are other percussion instruments. The parai is a traditional frame drum used in folk celebrations and funerals and the thappu, the urumi melam, the pambai, the udukkai and the kombu, a horn, are used in folk music and dance. The Tamil Nadu Government Music Colleges and Kalakshetra teach these instruments.

Making and Preservation

Instruments are crafted by hereditary artisans using wood, animal skin, metal and clay. Thanjavur, Chennai's Mylapore and Madurai have notable instrument makers. Preservation is promoted by the Sangeet Natak Akademi's museum of instruments and the Central Government awards.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include declining craftsmen, scarcity of jackfruit wood and materials, restrictions on animal hides, and electronic substitutes. The future involves fusion music, new materials, global popularity and digital tools to learn.

Quick Facts

- Indian instruments are classified as Tata (strings), Sushira (wind), Avanaddha (skin-covered percussion) and Ghana (solid percussion).
- The veena is an ancient plucked string instrument, with 24 frets and seven strings, associated with Saraswati.
- The mridangam is the double-headed barrel drum of Carnatic music.
- Thanjavur is famous for making veenas.
- The nadaswaram and thavil are played in Tamil Nadu temples and weddings.